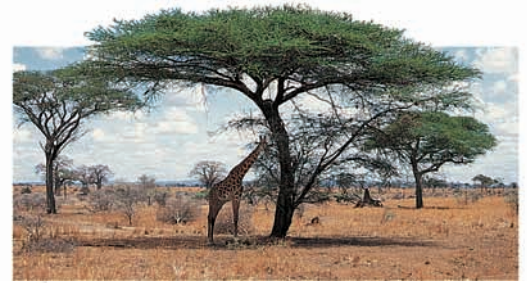


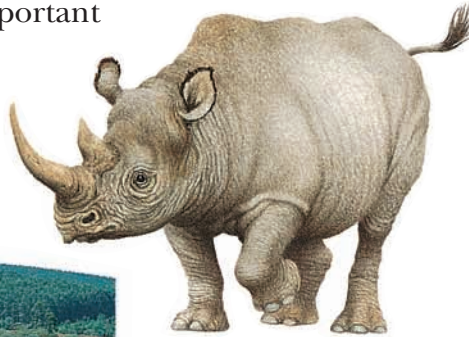
CENTRAL EAST AFRICA

A LINE OF DRAMATIC HIGHLANDS, volcanic mountains, gorges, and vast lakes runs through this region from Uganda in the north to Malawi in the south. This is part of a huge split in the Earth's crust known as the Great Rift Valley. Much of the rest of the landscape is flat grassland, called savanna – the perfect environment for big game animals, which draw thousands of tourists to countries such as Kenya and Tanzania. Growing tea and coffee provides another important source of income for the seven countries of the region. Mining and small-scale farming have always been important, and other industries are now increasing.



SAVANNA LANDSCAPE

Golden grasses that can grow up to 13 ft (4 m) tall cover the flat savanna. Rains come only once a year, so the grasses make the most of whatever water is available by spreading long roots deep into the soil. Needlelike leaves on acacia trees minimize water loss, while baobab trees can store water in their swollen trunks. To protect this landscape and its wildlife, vast areas have been turned into game parks, such as the Serengeti in Tanzania and the Masai Mara in Kenya.



ANIMALS OF THE SAVANNA
Rhinoceroses, giraffes, elephants, antelopes, and zebras wander across the savanna in search of pasture and water. They are closely watched by cheetahs, lions, and leopards, waiting to kill any weak animals. Finally, jackals and vultures will move in to finish off the carcasses.

Masai warriors and women wear jewelry – usually bead necklaces, large earrings, and copper bracelets.

Most Masai men have more than one wife. Each wife lives in a separate hut with her children.



FARMING IN THE HIGHLANDS

Most farmers in this region produce only enough food to feed their own families, either from small plots of land or from cattle herding. In the highland areas, which have a cool, moist climate, the volcanic soils are particularly fertile and companies own large farms where tea and coffee are grown for export. However, as the population has grown, farms have been divided up into impossibly small units. The soil has begun to erode, too, since farmers cultivate even the steepest slopes.



Tea is made from the leaves of the tea bush. Pickers have to push their way into the bushes to reach the freshest shoots, so they wear rubber aprons to protect themselves.

THE RIFT VALLEY

The Great Rift Valley stretches 4,350 miles (7,000 km) from Syria in Asia to Mozambique. Over millions of years, movement between two of the plates that form the Earth's crust has created this dramatic landscape. In some places, this movement has formed steep-sided valleys such as Kenya's Mau Escarpment. Elsewhere, volcanic peaks have erupted and wide plateaus, such as the Athi Plains in Kenya, have formed where lava has seeped through the Earth's surface.



Africa's tallest mountain is Mount Kilimanjaro, a dormant volcano in the Tanzanian part of the Rift Valley.



NOMADIC CATTLE FARMERS

In the lowland areas of central east Africa, where lack of rainfall makes growing crops difficult, nomadic people travel with herds of cattle, sheep, goats, and sometimes donkeys and camels in search of water and grazing. In Kenya, the Masai people herd humpbacked zebu cattle in the area south of Nairobi straddling the Tanzanian border. The Masai keep their cattle for milk and for blood, which they draw off from a vein through a thin reed to drink.